

LESSON GUIDE

Light & Shadow

Light is what makes drawing three-dimensional. Understanding how light falls across form — and the five distinct value zones it creates — is the single most powerful skill in representational drawing. Everything else is refinement of this.

4-WEEK PLAN

Week 1 — Light Direction & Logic

Set up a simple still life with a single strong directional light. Identify the light source, form shadow, cast shadow, and highlight before drawing anything.

Week 2 — Value Structure

Squint at your subject until detail disappears. Only two values should remain: light family and shadow family. Draw only these two values first.

Week 3 — Five Elements of Shading

Draw a sphere under direct light and identify all five elements: highlight, halftone, core shadow, reflected light, and cast shadow. Label them.

Week 4 — Complex Forms

Apply the five elements of shading to a more complex still life — a crumpled cloth, a face, or a hand. Work from simple to complex.

KEY CONCEPTS

Light Logic & Direction

Light travels in straight lines from a source. Every surface facing the source is lit; every surface turned away is in shadow. The logic is absolute.

Value Structure

The overall organization of light and dark across a composition. The first and most important design decision — establish it at thumbnail stage.

Five Elements of Shading

Highlight, halftone (lit surface), core shadow (darkest shadow), reflected light (ambient bounce in shadow), cast shadow. All five appear on every lit form.

Form Shadow vs. Cast Shadow

Form shadow is on the object itself, where the surface turns away from the light. Cast shadow is thrown onto another surface by the object blocking the light.

The Terminator

The edge where the lit side meets the shadow side. Hard on smooth surfaces, soft on rough ones. The terminator's position tells you the direction of the light.

Occlusion Shadow

The darkest shadow in any scene, found where surfaces are closest together and block the most ambient light. The contact point of an object with its ground plane.

ESSENTIAL RESOURCES

- James Gurney — Color and Light (YouTube channel and book)
- Ctrl+Paint — Value and light fundamentals module (free)
- Proko — Shading fundamentals for artists (YouTube)
- Watts Atelier — Light and shadow playlist (YouTube)
- Marco Bucci — How to shade — 10 levels of shading (YouTube)